The Removal of the Restrainer

The apostasy, the man of sin — and a third thing must come first: the Restrainer taken out of the way. Then the lawless one is revealed, and the Lord Jesus destroys him at His coming. God is in control from beginning to end.

Where this study fits

2 Thessalonians · seven studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–2
Introduction and Background

02 1:3–12
Paul's Admiration for the Thessalonians

03 2:1–5
Confusion Concerning the Coming

04 2:6–12
The Removal of the Restrainer

05 2:13–17
The Day of the Lord and Believers

06 3:1–12
Serving While Waiting

07 3:13–18
My Brother's Keeper

Grace and peace frame the letter (1:2; 3:16–18): persecution in chapter 1, prophecy in chapter 2, correction in chapter 3.

Three reasons they were not in the Day

Introduction · A–D

1 · The apostasy

- A falling away from the faith
- Worldwide and church-wide
- Studied in 2:3

2 · The man of sin revealed

- A seven-year covenant with Israel
- Dan 9:27
- Israel's prophecy clock restarts

3 · The Restrainer removed

- "Until He is taken out of the way"
- 2:6–7
- Today's study

"Do you not remember that when I was with you I told you these things?" (2:5) — Paul expected them to remember what he taught them. And why not?

Who is the Restrainer?

2 Thessalonians 2:6–7 · I.A and I.C — A force and a person

v.6 — “what is restraining”
τὸ κατέχον neuter

- A force — a “what”
- Fits pneuma, a neuter noun
- Must be strong enough to hold back Satan

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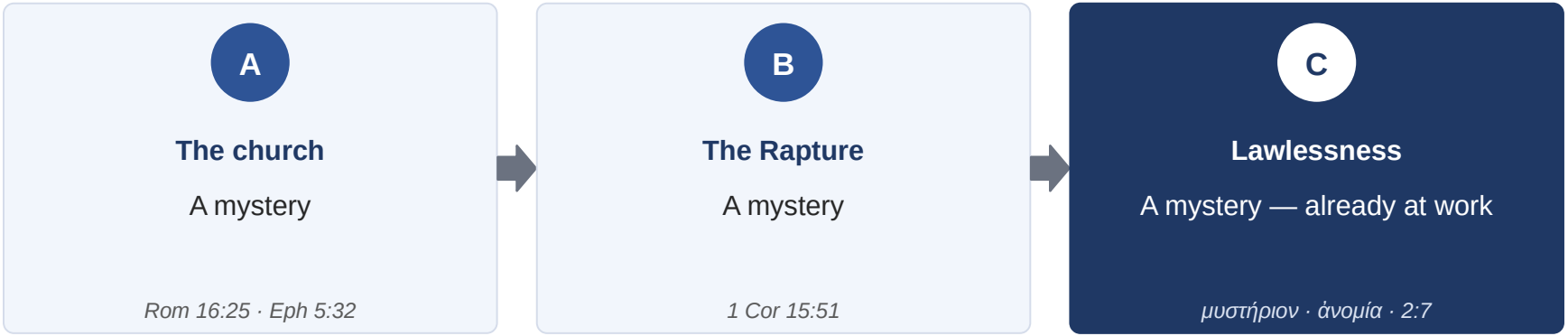
v.7 — “He who now restrains”
ὁ κατέχων masculine

- A person — a “He”
- As Jesus spoke of the Spirit (John 14–16)
- Indwells the church until removed

The Spirit cannot leave a believer (“forever,” John 14:16). If the Restrainer is taken out of the way, the church is taken out with Him.

The mystery of lawlessness

2 Thessalonians 2:7a · I.B — The demonic activity



Already at work
ἐνεργέω G1754

- Satan’s power operating now
- Same root in v.9 and v.11

Only God can restrain it

- Satan is the mightiest angel
- Michael: “The Lord rebuke you” (Jude 9)

When, who, why

2 Thessalonians 2:8–10 · II — The prophetic climax

When · v.8
ἐπιφάνεια brightness of His coming

- Revealed after the removal
- Consumed by the breath of His mouth
- Destroyed at Christ’s coming

Who · vv.9–10a
σημεῖον · τέρας signs · wonders

- According to the working of Satan
- Lying wonders imitate the Messiah
- Deceiving those who perish

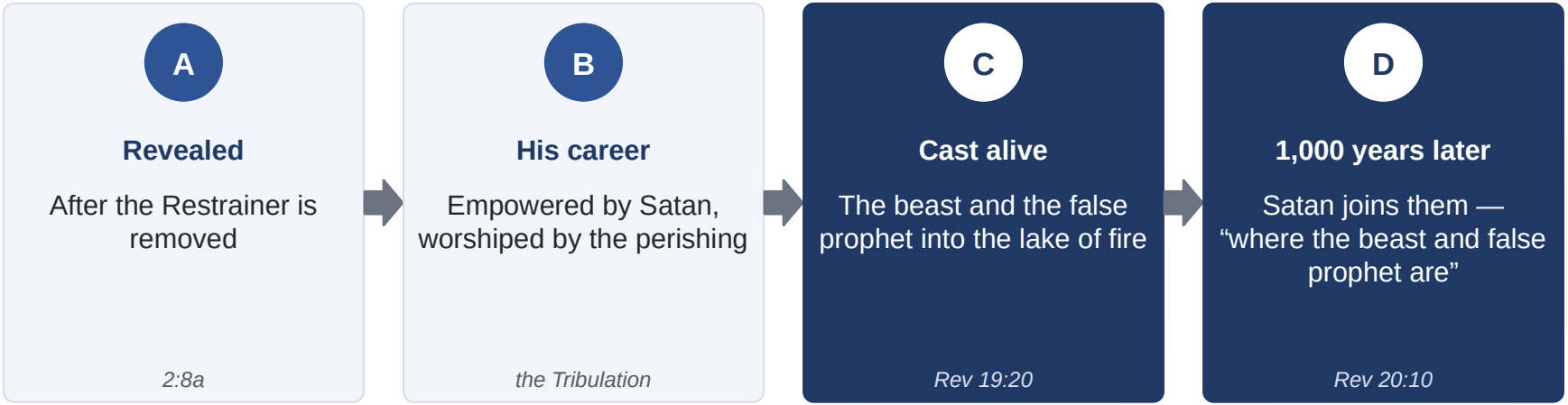
Why · v.10b
ἀπάτη deception · G539

- “They did not receive the love of the truth”
- They traded the cross for the show

Verse 8 is his whole career in three lines: he comes up, he rebels, he is thrown into the lake of fire.

God wins

2 Thessalonians 2:8 · II.A.2–3 — Revelation 19:20 and 20:10



“I looked at the last page: He wins. And we’re winning with Him.”

Delusion, damnation — and a question

2 Thessalonians 2:11–12 · III — The practical conclusion

Delusion and damnation
πλάνη · ψεῦδος delusion · the lie

- Strong delusion — a working of error
- They believe the lie: the Antichrist is God
- Condemned — declared and deserved

vs

Can those left behind believe?
“a great multitude” Rev 7:9

- Yes — the 144,000 and a great multitude
- But many take the mark — no turning back
- Eternal life is always by faith in Christ

All rejection of Christ’s offer of eternal life — offered at the cost of His own life — deserves eternal punishment. All judgment is given to the Son (John 5:27).

Discuss and apply

2 Thessalonians 2:6–12 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. Why does the teacher identify the Restrainer as the Holy Spirit indwelling the church?

2. Why will the Antichrist work signs and wonders, and how does the teacher connect this to some miracle workers today?

Apply

Don’t Be Impressed by the Show
When you hear a claim of the miraculous this week, ask first what it teaches about Jesus and the gospel.

Remember Who Wins
Read Revelation 19:11–20:10 and thank God specifically for each victory Christ wins.

In one line: The Spirit in the church holds back lawlessness until He is taken out of the way — and then Christ destroys the lawless one. He wins.